Year of Turbulence

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› **In December, IndiGo, India's largest airline, cancelled nearly 3,000 flights over three days after failing to comply with new pilot duty-time rules, stranding tens of thousands of passengers and triggering government intervention**

When the Tata Group acquired Air India in 2022 as part of the government's divestment effort, hope had soared that the national airline would now see a professional hand. But those expectations dashed to the ground along with Flight 171 on June 12, when a London Gatwick-bound Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner crashed shortly after take-off from Ahmedabad airport, killing 241 people on board and 19 on the ground.

An interim report, to be published mandatorily within a month of a disaster, did not blame anyone. The 15-page document released by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau in July referred to a last-minute exchange between the captain and first officer, captured on the flight recorder. According to the report, the fuel switches of both engines were in the 'cut-off' position, with one pilot heard asking the other why he had cut them off, and the other responding that he had not.

The conversation sparked fresh conspiracy theories around the incident. But it did not deflect the sharp public scrutiny the legacy problems at the country's second-largest airline came under. The Tatas' acquisition of the airline has not obviated the need to modernise its fleet, gaps in aircraft maintenance, technical oversight and a shortage of pilots. N. Chandrasekaran, chairman of Tata Sons and Air India, told employees soon after the tragedy that the incident was a "catalyst" to create "a safer airline"—a promise that is expected to test the airline for years.

But Air India was not the only airline to have faced turbulence this year. Disruption engulfed IndiGo as well in December. India's largest airline with more than 60 per cent share of the domestic market, IndiGo operated more than 400 aircraft, ran around 2,300 flights a day, flew to over 90 domestic and 45 international destinations, and carried an average of half a million passengers daily. But between December 4 and 6, the airlines had to cancel an unprecedented 2,948 domestic flights, 1,588 on December 5 alone, after failing to comply with new Flight Duty Time Limitations (FDTL) rules laid down by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), which govern how long pilots can work, the rest they must take and the number of night landings they are permitted to perform.

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ARUN KUMAR

Tens of thousands of passengers were stranded, airport lounges overflowed with people and the terminals with baggage even as air fares spiked sharply, prompting the DGCA to step in to rein in prices. IndiGo's shares slid on the bourses. Even as the airline's leadership issued apologies, the Union civil aviation ministry promised punitive action and cut IndiGo's winter schedule by 10 per cent in an effort to stabilise operations.

Together, the crises did not bode well for an aviation sector that is one of the world's fastest-growing and the third-largest domestic market globally, with passenger traffic growing annually at 10-12 per cent. But if there was one lesson 2025 left us with, it was that growth cannot come at the cost of safety and airlines cannot forgo rules in their relentless pursuit of profit. ■